



with a recorded history beginning 4,000 years ago with the **Shang** dynasty. Over thousands of years China has developed a rich culture. Ninety-two percent of the country are **Han** Chinese; the rest of the population belong to

other minority groups, each of which has varied traditions, languages or dialects, and religions. Most Chinese live in the eastern part of the country.

Chinese minority groups

There are 55 minority ethnic groups in China, in addition to the majority, Han. Fifty-three of these use spoken languages of their own and 23 have their own written languages. Most of the remaining eight percent live in the vast areas of the west, southwest, and northwest.

HAN

The Han Chinese are the largest ethnic group in the world. The Han culture is incredibly old and the language of the Han, commonly known as Mandarin Chinese, is not only the most widely spoken in the world, but is also the most ancient language in the world.



DAI

The Dai people live in the southern part of Yunnan Province and have a rich, colorful culture. They live in bamboo houses and have a history stretching back more than 1,000 years.

BAI

The Bai people have a population of around two million, 90 percent of whom live in the Bai Autonomous County in Yunnan Province. They are known for their worship of the color white.



UIGUR

The Uigur people, with a total population of 7.21 million, have lived at the foot of Mt Tianshan, western China, for several centuries. The Uigurs rely heavily on agriculture as their main source of survival, planting cotton, wheat, corn, and rice. The Uigurs follow the Islamic faith, which influences family life, marriages, and food.

The Uigur people have their own language and alphabet.